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PRIVACY IS DEAD: SO SAYS ERIC SCHMIDT

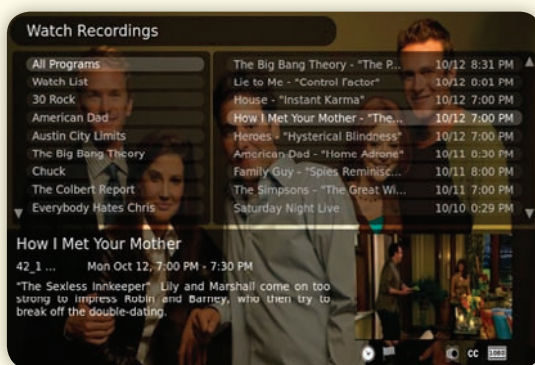
When the CEO of Google, the company that is usually under fire for searching through your personal data to try and serve up relevant advertising, says in an interview that we are putting up too much personal information on the web, something tells us it's time to sit up and take notice. Repent ye sinners, the end is nigh!
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account, it will be empty; you'll need to populate it with the appropriate channel guide, which you can find by entering your zip code and choosing one from the menu that appears. I chose the appropriate Comcast Digital entry for the town I live in.

MythTV's front end works a lot like a TiVo or cable service—provided DVR, but there are about 50 times the number of menu options once you start digging. Fortunately, you can ignore almost all of it. You navigate menus with the cursor keys, not the mouse cursor. You'll be able to see channel guides for your system and schedule recordings. If you don't see the right channel guide, you may need to return to the MythTV Backend Setup. On our system, running channel scans took a few tries. Note that you'll need to run at least one scan before you can watch live TV for the first time. You can also select from a number of built-in UI themes. I liked Mythbuntu's UI theme the best, but all of the older MythTV themes are here too—even that ugly blue one from five years ago.

Finishing the Job

To complete the system, you'll need to set up the remote control. That's especially true if you have a cable box and want to change channels through MythTV. Unfortunately, getting the remote control to work under Linux is tough. Heitmueller said that IR support varies from kernel to kernel and distro to distro—not to mention by which TV tuner card you're using. In the case of the HVR-1600, there are two different types of IR to setup: IR receive, for using the remote control, and IR transmit, for MythTV to control the cable box. (Read the Hauppauge HVR-1600 wiki for detailed



instructions.) Note that in some cases, such as with Verizon FIOS, you can control the box via FireWire; we didn't try that, though.

All of that is fine for standard-definition TV, but recording in HD is trickier. We ended up steering clear of it for this story, although there are a few ways around the problem. Cable providers deliver basic broadcast-equivalent stations as unencrypted MPEG streams (called ClearQAM). MythTV can record those via the HVR-1600. Beyond that, everything else will be encrypted. The Hauppauge HD-PVR will let you record all channels, including premium channels like HBO, via the component inputs and hardware-based H.264 compression.

So there it is: a fully open-source DVR box running under Linux—specifically, Ubuntu, and with a wireless keyboard and mouse. You can add additional tuner cards as your needs increase. You can also use the system as a central media repository for your photos, music, and video files. It turns out that there's very little you can't do with a Linux-based media center, at least when compared with more typical consumer PCs. In our book, that makes this a project worth doing for just about any media enthusiast—and one that doesn't bust the budget, either.



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